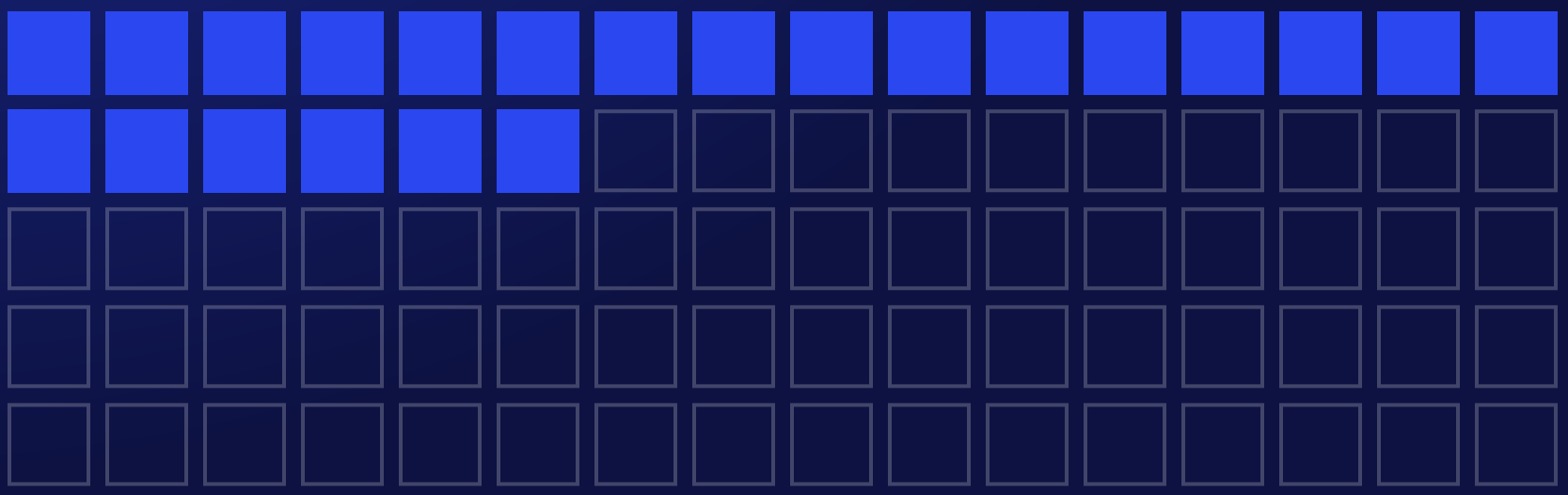
Cut reporting upkeep without losing what matters

How to find what reporting really costs, decide which reports stay, and keep the count from growing back.



22 reports kept or rebuilt 58 retired or merged

80 → 22

reports, every critical decision still covered

~35 hrs

analyst hours a week freed (base case)

Tony Alunni · Finance and Strategy

ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

Upkeep consumes 40% of the team's capacity

Before anyone builds a new report, the team spends two of every five hours keeping 80 old ones running.

EXHIBIT 1 · Where a 200-hour week goes (5 analysts × 40 scheduled hours) ILLUSTRATIVE



Shared source fixes 24 hrs
fixed, whatever the report count

Per-report upkeep 56 hrs = 80 reports × 0.7 hrs
checks after breaks, fixes, user questions, small tweaks

FOUR WARNING SIGNS

Capacity
Two of every five hours go to maintaining existing reports

Duplication
Requests arrive for reports that already exist under another name

Findability
Users cannot tell which of several similar reports to trust

Consistency
The same metric shows different values in different reports

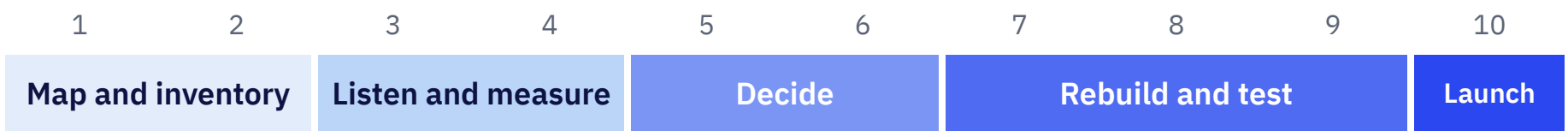
Upkeep share is a scenario input. Scheduled hours, not available hours.

Agree the scope and decision rights before changing any report

EXHIBIT 2 · One-page project charter ILLUSTRATIVE

Problem	80 reports absorb 40% of team hours, and no one has a single view of what matters
Objective	Recover analyst capacity while keeping every critical decision supported
In scope	Report inventory, consolidation, templates, catalog, intake process
Out of scope	Changes to source systems (owned by IT) and new data platforms
Decision rights	**Business leaders approve** priorities and every retirement. The reporting lead recommends and builds. IT fixes source data.
Success measures	Upkeep hours, request turnaround, critical uses still covered, owner sign-off
Upfront cost	About 340 analyst hours over 10 weeks, the investment the capacity gain must repay

TIMELINE · WEEKS 1 TO 10

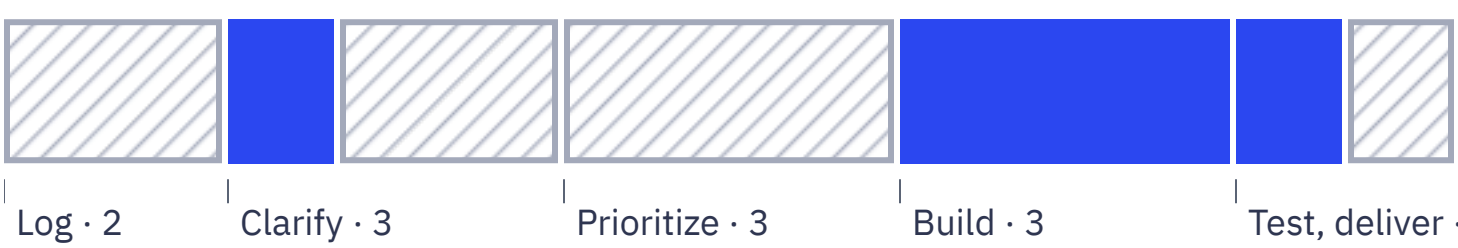


Requests spend 8 of 13 days waiting

Build time is not the problem. Requests sit in inboxes, wait for clarification and wait again for a priority call.

EXHIBIT 3 · Request flow, business days (bar length = elapsed time) ILLUSTRATIVE

Before



13 days
5 active · 8 waiting

Target



8 days
5 active · 3 waiting

Log 1 · Clarify 1 · Prioritize 1 · Build 3 · Test, deliver 2

Active work Waiting

> **What removes the waits:** one intake form captures requirements up front, every request is acknowledged within 2 business days, and a standing priority list agreed with the business replaces ad hoc escalation.

Combine what users say with what usage shows

The survey tells you what people need. Usage tells you how often they reach for it. Neither alone proves a report is critical.

EXHIBIT 4 · Cumulative share of report views, 80 reports ranked by use ILLUSTRATIVE



84 of 140

users answered a questionnaire with a 2-week deadline (60%)

20 of 20

executives and directors covered, by survey or follow-up

12

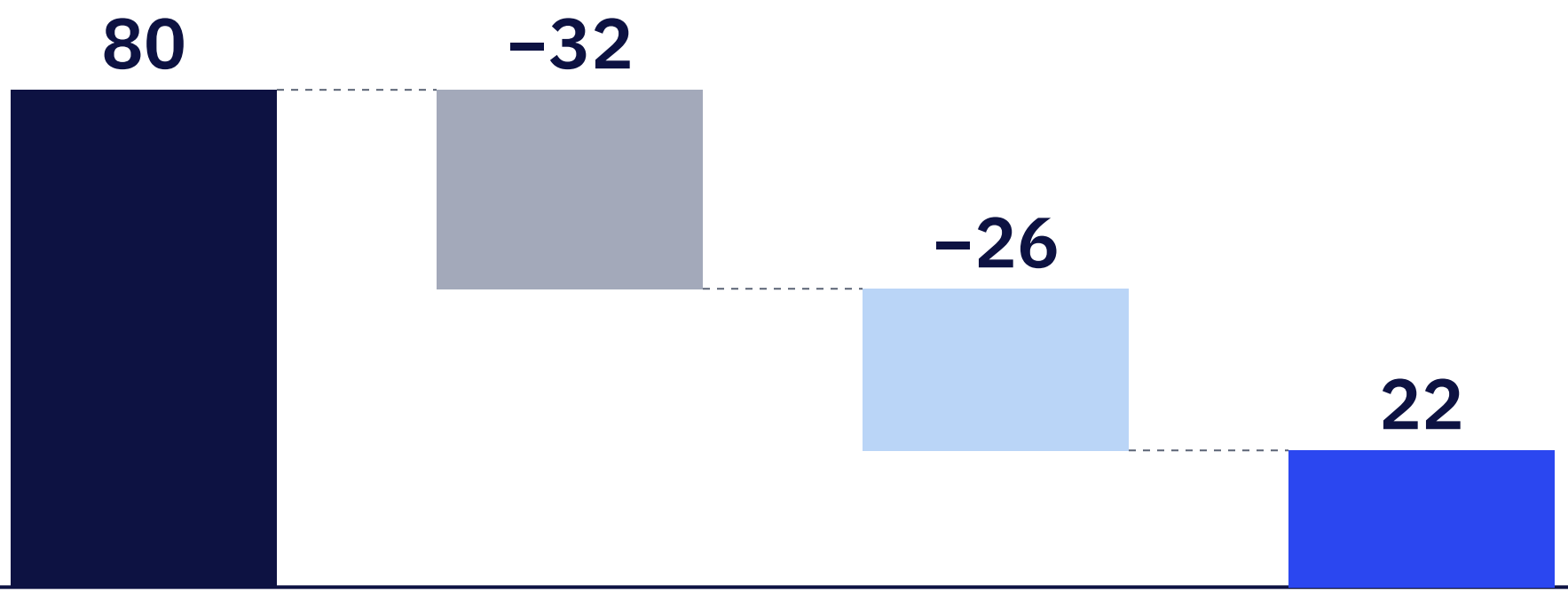
follow-ups: 6 leaders who did not reply, 6 owners of reports no one named

Views: interactive use by named users over 90 days. Scheduled distributions and service accounts are excluded and reviewed separately. Survey answers are self-reported.

Use explicit rules to keep, merge or retire each report

EXHIBIT 5 · From 80 reports to 22

ILLUSTRATIVE



Starting reports	Retired	Merged	Reports after
		34 reports become 8	14 kept + 8 merged

Retire 32

Under 3 named users in 90 days, no scheduled distribution, and the owner confirms no control, regulatory or period-end use

Merge 34 → 8

Overlaps another report's core metrics and audience. Fold into one owned report

Keep 14

Widely used, distinct and owned. Move to the standard template

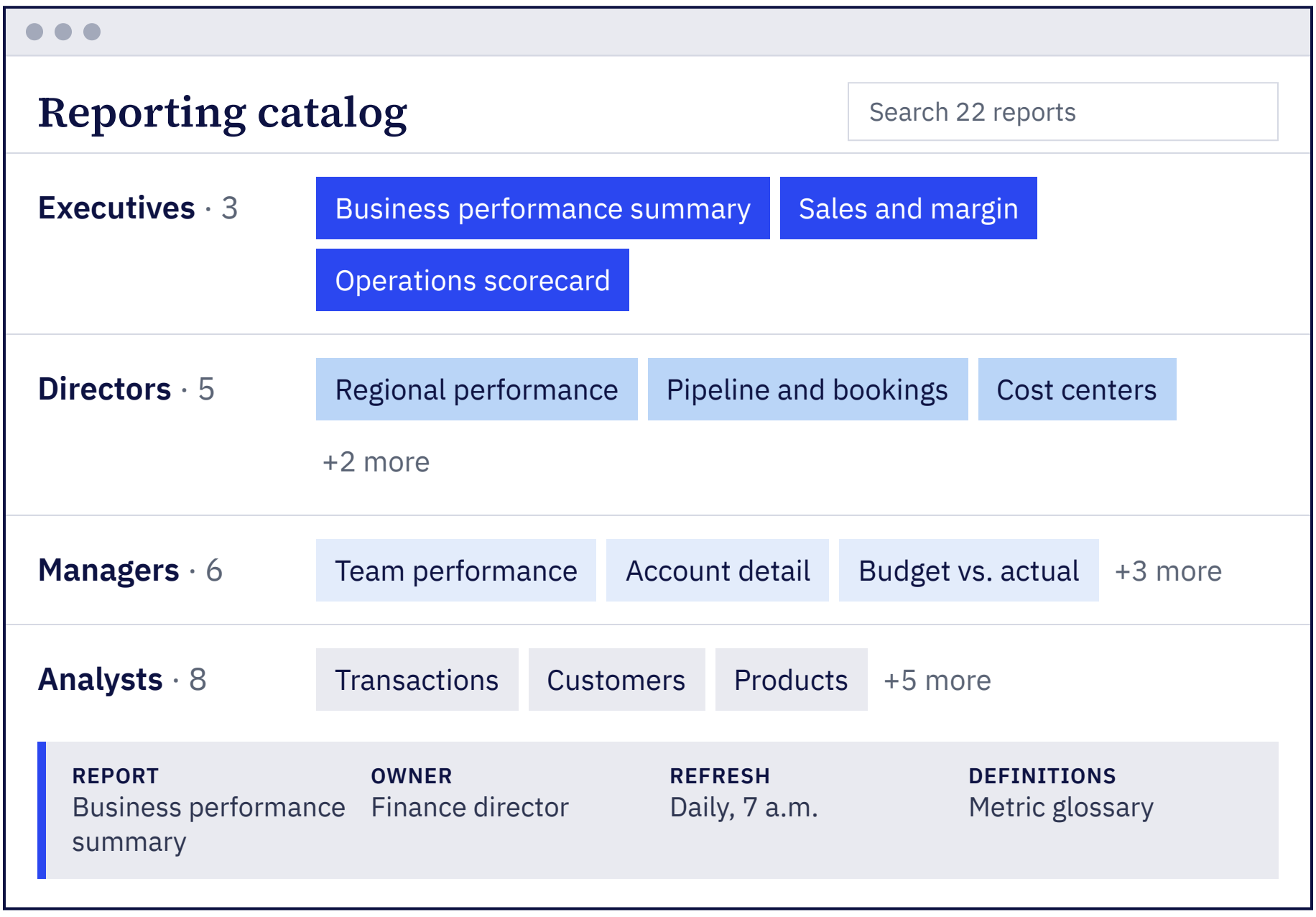
Example judgment call. A regional leader relies on a weekly regional view that duplicates the director report. Resolution: keep the regional cut as a filtered page inside the director report, approved by that leader and the report owner.

Safeguards on every retirement: 2 weeks' notice to users, 60-day archive, owner sign-off.

Give users one entry point to 22 owned reports

One catalog, organized by who uses each report. Detail increases as you move from executives to analysts.

EXHIBIT 6 · Catalog landing page (wireframe) ILLUSTRATIVE



Sections show the primary audience, not access limits. Every report has one owner, the shared template and defined metrics.

Model the capacity gain and show what drives it

Shared fixes do not shrink, and each merged report costs more to maintain. The gain comes from per-report work that disappears.

EXHIBIT 7 · Weekly upkeep, three scenarios (hours) ILLUSTRATIVE

Driver	Conservative	Base	Upside
ASSUMPTIONS			
Shared source fixes, hrs	32	**24**	16
Upkeep per old report, hrs	0.6	**0.7**	0.8
Merged report vs. old report	2.5×	**2.0×**	1.5×
RESULTS			
Upkeep before, hrs	80	**80**	80
Upkeep after, hrs	52	**45**	37
Capacity freed, hrs a week	**28**	**35**	**43**
Capacity payback after launch*	12 wks	**10 wks**	8 wks

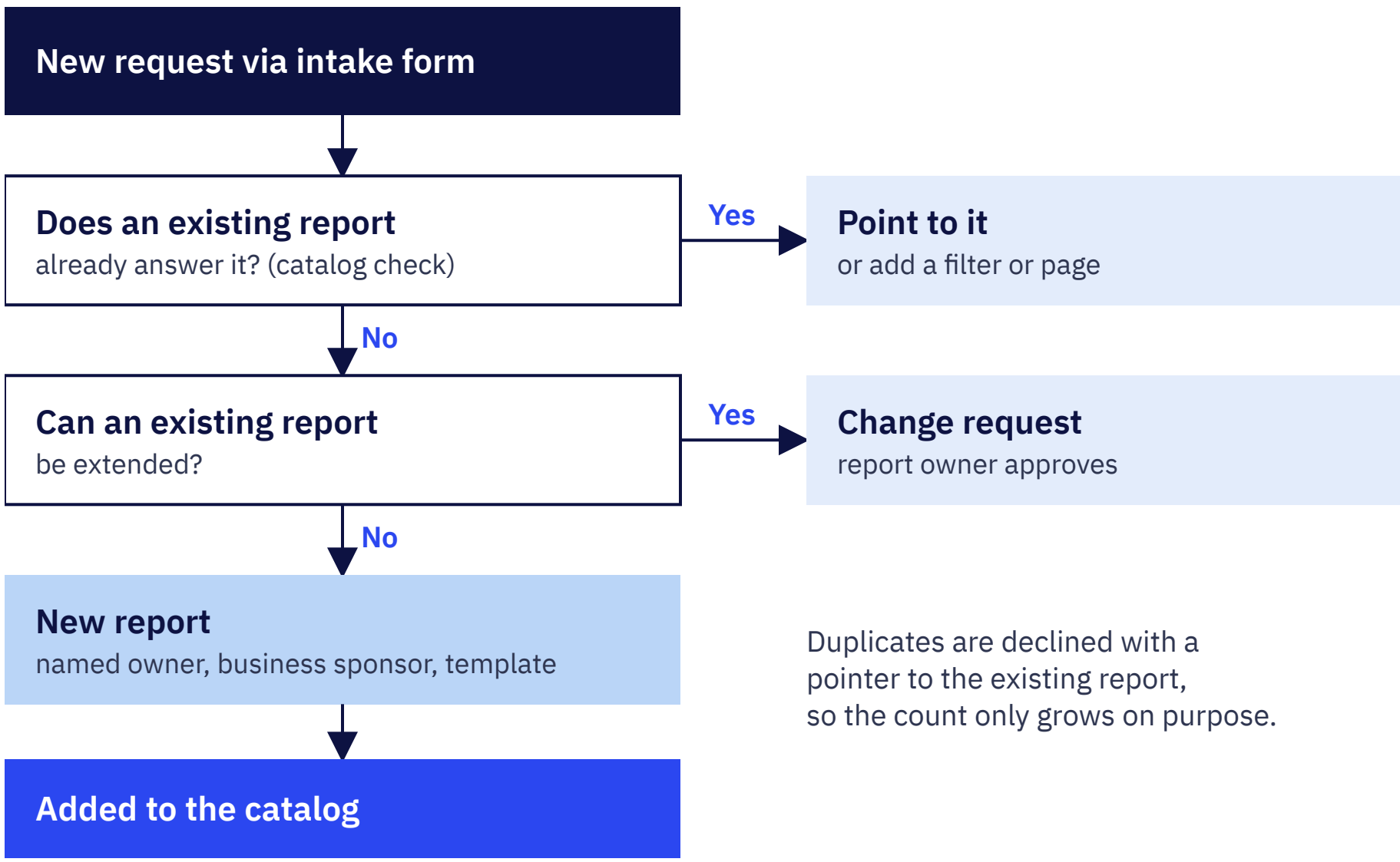
Each scenario starts at 80 upkeep hours; the workload mix and consolidation effort vary. *Weeks after launch to repay 340 setup hours, excluding the 10-week project.

> **Capacity, not cash.** At an assumed $60 loaded hourly cost over 50 working weeks, the base case frees about $105K a year of analyst time to redeploy to analysis. Request turnaround target: 13 to 8 business days in every scenario.

After = shared + 14 kept × rate + 8 merged × rate × multiplier

Make every new report pass a catalog and ownership check

EXHIBIT 8 · Intake decision path ILLUSTRATIVE



2-day acknowledgment
Every request gets an owner and a priority

Quarterly usage review
Low usage triggers a review; retire only after critical-use checks and owner approval

One template
Same layout and metric definitions everywhere

Named owners
No owner, no report

Protect decision support as you reduce reporting upkeep

1 **Put a number on upkeep**
Hours spent keeping reports alive are the business case.

2 **Agree decision rights first**
The business approves what goes; the reporting team recommends.

3 **Pair what users say with usage**
Then go find the people who did not answer.

4 **Decide by rules, allow exceptions**
Rules for speed, owner sign-off for anything critical.

5 **Gate what comes in**
A catalog check and an owner keep the count from growing back.

About the author. I have led reporting and analytics teams, agreed priorities with business partners, consolidated overlapping reports and worked with IT on source-data issues. The company, figures and events in this playbook are illustrative.

The same approach applies to management packs, budget reporting and recurring variance analysis.